

Before embarking on meaningful research using qualitative approach, it is important to understand the meaning, nature of reality, methodology and the essence of these two paradigms. Let us begin with interpretative paradigm.

5.2 INTERPRETIVE PARADIGM

Interpretive research assumes “that our knowledge of reality is gained only through social constructions such as language, consciousness, shared meanings, documents, tools, and other artifacts” (Klein & Myers, p. 69). As the term indicates, interpretive paradigm looks for understanding of a particular context. Interpretivists believe that it is important to understand the context in which research is conducted for proper interpretation of the data. The interest of interpretivists lies not in the generation of a new theory, but to judge or evaluate and refine interpretive theories. Researchers using an interpretive approach aim to uncover meaning towards a better understanding of the issues involved. The underlying ontological assumption of interpretive paradigm is subjectivism as here reality is viewed as socially constructed and interpreted. Epistemological assumption is that knowledge of reality is obtained from the accounts that social actors provide. Neuman (1997) affirms that “social reality is based on people’s definition of it” (p. 69). From the previous assertions, it is apparent that interpretive researchers do not recognize the existence of an objective world. On the contrary, they see the world strongly bounded by particular time and specific context. Therefore, the epistemological question, “What is the nature of the relationship between the knower or would-be knower and what can be known” (Guba & Lincoln, 1994, p. 108) must be answered in a consistent way with the ontological view. The interpretive researcher’s epistemological assumption is that “findings are literally created as the investigation proceeds” (Guba & Lincoln, p. 111). Moreover, they explicitly recognise that “understanding social reality requires understanding how practices and meanings are formed and informed by the language and tacit norms shared by humans working towards some shared goal” (Orlikowski & Baroudi, 1991, p. 14).

Interpretive research focuses on identifying, documenting, and ‘knowing’ – through interpretation of :

- world views,
- values,
- meanings,
- beliefs,
- thoughts and the general characteristics of life events, situations, ceremonies and specific phenomena under investigation,
- the goal being to document and interpret as fully as possible the totality of whatever is being studied in particular contexts from the people’s viewpoint or frame of reference.

Interpretivists assert that all research is influenced and shaped by pre-existing theories and world-views of the researchers. The terms, procedures and data of research have meaning because a group of scholars has agreed on that meaning.

Research is thus a socially constructed activity. Three other approaches support the philosophy of interpretive paradigm. They are Verstehen, hermeneutics and phenomenology. Verstehen stresses on the understanding of the particulars of a situation, hermeneutics emphasizes on the importance of language and context in understanding and phenomenology on people's perception of the world.

Methodology

Foundationalism is an approach that asserts research can begin with **self-evident truths** which can serve as the starting point for our understanding of the world. Interpretivists are anti-foundationalists as they believe that the standards that guide research are **products of a particular group or culture**. They use a broad range of qualitative methods and gather thoughtful reflections of experienced practitioners. Interpretative approaches rely heavily on naturalistic methods (interviewing and observation) and their methods generally ensure an adequate dialogue between the researchers and the people with whom they interact to be able to construct a meaningful reality. These meanings emerge from the research process. Certain methodologies used in interpretive research are:

Naturalistic inquiry, that uses first-hand observation to understand human action and studies real-life situations as they unfold. It is non-manipulative and non-controlling, hence has lack of predetermined constraints on outcomes;

Phenomenologic methodologies, rely on descriptions of conscious experiences to develop understanding of the meaning of human action;

Constructivism, makes use of perception or self-experience in making and structuring knowledge;

Ethnographic inquiry, rely on self-experiencing the culture of participants in the field;

Symbolic interactionism, understands human action as per the meanings derived by the human beings for particular objects and people.

Some other methods for data-collection are surveys, interviews, field observation, witness accounts, focus group discussion. Interpretive research adds to the understanding of different contexts and situations. Interpretivists argue that research results should be applied to higher, conceptual level. From the data, a researcher tries to understand multiple perspectives on the same topic. For analyzing the meaning of data, interpretive researchers may use and conduct research by methods from another paradigm (eg. Post-positivism) also and doing so would lead to reinterpreting the meaning of results by another perspective.

With a philosophical alignment with interpretive naturalistic orientations, interpretive description acknowledges the constructed and contextual nature of human experience that at the same time allows for shared realities (Thorne, Reimer Kirkham, & MacDonald-Emes, 1997). Key axioms of naturalistic inquiry, such as those delineated by Lincoln and Guba (1985), provide philosophical underpinnings for research design, including:

- 1) There are multiple constructed realities that can be studied only holistically. Thus, reality is complex, contextual, constructed, and ultimately subjective.

- 2) The inquirer and the “object” of inquiry interact to influence one another; indeed, the knower and known are inseparable.
- 3) No *a priori* theory could possibly encompass the multiple realities that are likely to be encountered; rather, theory must emerge or be grounded in the data.

Research Strategy for Interpretivism

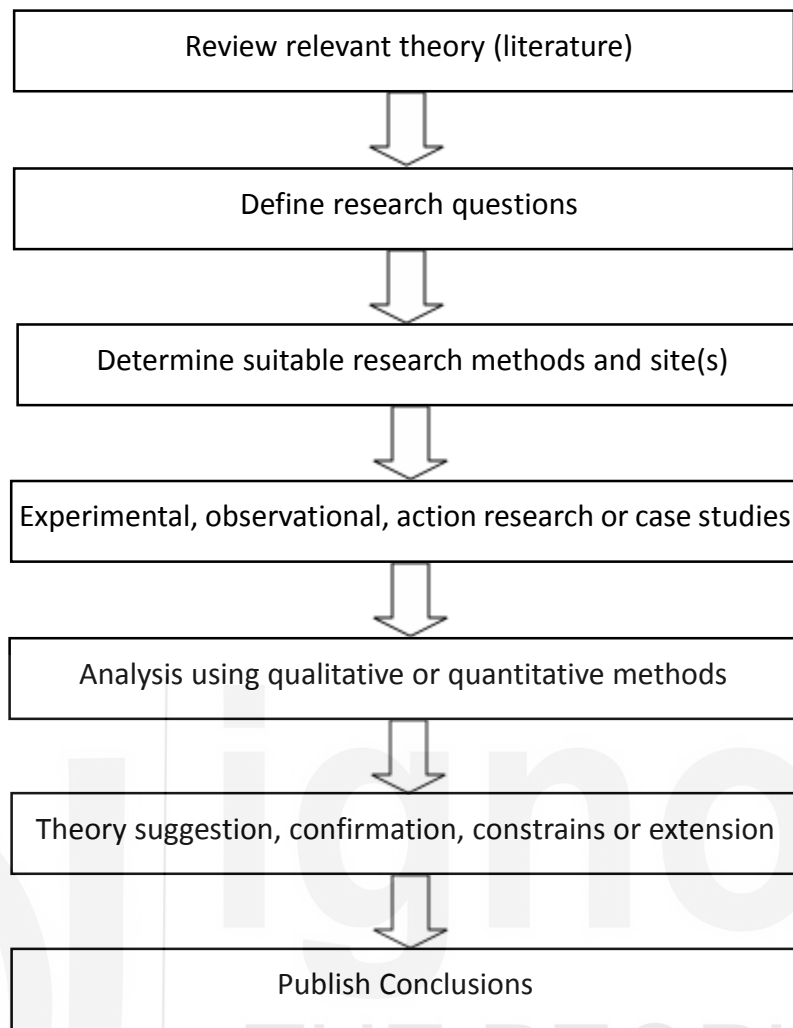
Broadly there are four distinct research strategies that work with different ontological assumptions. Abduction strategy best fulfills the needs of interpretive researcher as it starts with laying the concepts and meanings that are contained in social quarter’s accounts of activities related to a research problem.

As interpretivists construct reality on the accounts of social actors present in a specific situation, it is important to take into account the different perspectives of each participant. One can understand the complexity of the issue through the following example, excerpts taken from Andrade, 2009.

Let’s imagine a scenario at the beach in which a huge wave is approaching the shore. There is an excited surfer on top of the big wave and two scared children in a small inflatable boat right below the colossal wave. On the shore, a girl is admiring her boyfriend’s dexterity and the petrified children’s mother is watching the looming mass of water approaching the boat. On the adjacent cliff there is a relaxed monk meditating on the infiniteness of the universe, while enjoying the sea breeze and the sound of the sea. If we want to conduct research on what that wave means for beach-goers, our results will depend on who the respondent is. Interviewing one of the participants would give insights from that participant’s perspective only, which may be insufficient, or even misleading, because their personal and intimate experiences with the wave are quite different from that of the others. If the interpretive researcher wants to create an integral and persuasive piece of research around this phenomenon, each participant’s different perspectives should be included.

To conduct interpretive research on a certain setting, intense and long-term participant observation is required, followed by deliberate and long-term reflection on what was observed. Interpretive researchers start out with the assumption that access to reality (given or socially constructed) is only through social constructions such as language, consciousness and shared meanings. Interpretive studies generally attempt to understand phenomena through the meanings that people assign to them and interpretive methods of research in IS are “aimed at producing an understanding of the context of the information system, and the process whereby the information system influences and is influenced by the context. Interpretive research does not predefine dependent and independent variables, but focuses on the full complexity of human sense making as the situation emerges.

The life-cycle of theory-generation under interpretive paradigm has been depicted in the following flow-chart:



Criticism

Researchers who wish to use interpretive framework for their case-studies are cautioned not to lose theoretical sensitivity. Strauss and Corbin (1990, p. 41) describe theoretical sensitivity as the “awareness of the subtleties of meaning of data” and elaborate that “one can come to a research situation with varying degrees of sensitivity depending upon previous reading and experience with or relevant to that area.” Ultimately, the researcher has to evaluate the relevance of their preliminary theoretical framework vis-à-vis the actual findings (Urquhart, 2001, 2007). The criteria to be kept in mind for using interpretive case studies aiming for theory-building can be seen in the appendix to the unit.

Differences of Interpretive paradigm from post-positivism can be broadly summarized in the table below:

Differences between Post-positivism and Interpretivism on Five major Issues

	Post-positivism	Interpretivism
Nature of reality	External to human mind	Socially constructed
Purpose of research	Find Universals	Reflect understanding
Acceptable methods and data	Scientific method	Subjective and Objective research methods are acceptable

	Post-positivism	Interpretivism
Meaning of data	Falsification Use to test theory	Understanding is contextual. Universals are deemphasized
Relationship of research to practice	Separate activities. Research guides practice	Integrated activities. Both guide and become the other.

(Source: Foundations of qualitative research by Jerry W. Willis (2007) p.95)

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Explain how interpretive framework is a departure from post-positivism?
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- 2) Outline the methodology of interpretive research using a suitable example from your locality.
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- 3) How do the ontological and epistemological assumptions underlying interpretive paradigm guide the researcher to the methodology of research, data-collection and analysis?
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5.3 CRITICAL THEORY PARADIGM

Critical theories share some ideas of the interpretative paradigm, but what makes it different is that critical paradigm focuses on oppression. Critical social scientists believe it necessary to understand the lived experience of real people in context. Persons can perceive reality outside them and represent that reality with language. Also, reality is defined by the interaction between the knower and the known. Critical approaches examine social conditions and uncover oppressive power arrangements. 'Critical theory' is a term that can apply to a number of movements in the social sciences. As it is based on ideology of class conflict, the critical theorists whose objective is to find out power-relationships among the different sections of the society (between the doers and the oppressed), it is sometimes referred as 'ideologically oriented inquiry, neo-Marxism, materialism, the Frankfurt School and freireism. Critical theory was built on the foundation of Marxism which perceived conflicts between classes in society and believed that it could be reformed only via radical transformation of the society. The roots of the critical theory can be traced to the Frankfurt school or the Institute for Social

Research. It was established as a school of thought primarily by five Frankfurt school theoreticians; Herbert Marcuse, Theodor Adorno, Max Horkheimer, Walter Benjamin and Erich Fromm. The underlying ontological assumption of critical theory paradigm is substantialism wherein matter constitutes the reality. However, epistemologically people interpret reality differently in different times and places. Critical Theory is a theoretical tradition developed most notably by Horkheimer, Adorno, Marcuse at the Frankfurt School. Their work is a critical response to the works of Marx, Kant, Hegel and Weber.

- **Historical ontology** – assumes that there is a ‘reality’ that is apprehendable. This is a reality created and shaped by social, political, cultural, economic, ethnic and gender-based forces that have been reified or crystallized over time into social structures that are taken to be natural or real. People, including researchers, function under the assumption that for all practical purposes these structures are real. Critical theorists believe this assumption is inappropriate.
- **Modified transactional or subjectivist epistemology** – we cannot separate ourselves from what we know and this inevitably influences inquiry. What can be known is inextricably tied to the interaction between a particular investigator and a particular object or group.

Purpose of Research

Research that aspires to be critical seeks, as its **purpose of inquiry**, to confront injustices in society. Following a tradition associated with Antonio Gramsci, critical researchers aim to understand the relationship between societal structures (especially those economic and political) and ideological patterns of thought that constrain the human imagination and thus limit opportunities for confronting and changing unjust social systems. Critical theorists are committed to understanding the complexity of such relations, however, and thus distance themselves from what they see as reductionist Marxist approaches. Critical theorists hold that these earlier approaches offered no ability to explain social change. Thus, in contrast to what they believe was an overemphasis on the determinative nature of economic and political structures, critical theorists are interested in social change as it occurs in relation to social struggle. Critical researchers assume that the knowledge developed in their research may serve as a first step toward addressing such injustices. As an approach with a definite normative dimension, the research aims for a transformative outcome, and thus is not interested in “knowledge for knowledge’s sake.”

Critical Theory is multi-disciplinary. It finds its applications in anthropology, economics, art criticism, education, history, psychology, political science, sociology and theology. An interesting question is why and where to apply critical theory paradigm in research. To begin with, research and practice are integrated activities in the critical paradigm. It not only studies power relationships which are critical factors in the society, the injustices and the inequities, the contradictions and the incoherencies, but also aims at helping and empowering those who are oppressed to free themselves from their oppression.

Critical theory paradigm should be applied where the objective of the researcher is to analyse the power structures in a set-up or social problems arising of such structures. For example, it can be used to understand wage inequities between male, female and child workers in the society.

Nature of reality: Critical theorists like post-positivists believe that reality is material and external to human mind but they interpret it differently. They question/critique the existing reality and analyze why such a reality exists and whether it contributes positively/negatively to human mind. Further, they also advocate evolving ways and means to reform the existing system if it is bifurcating the society into the have's and the have not's.

Methodology: Critical theorists suggest two kinds of research methodologies, namely ideology critique and action research, for undertaking research work. They rely on methods combining observation and interviewing with approaches that foster conversation and reflection. They try to challenge guiding assumptions and they begin this by asking people to reflect and question their current experience with regard to values identified. In doing research, they not only try to define a situation but change the situation.

As a research methodology, critical theory adopts an overtly critical approach to inquiry. It precedes with an attitude of suspicion, calling into question not only the data itself, but also the researcher, the research design and interpretation of findings. From a critical theory viewpoint, the task of the social scientist has three dimensions:

- 1) To understand the ideologically distorted subjective situation of some individual or group;
- 2) To explore the forces that has caused that situation;
- 3) To show that these forces can be overcome through awareness of them on the part of the oppressed individual or group in question.

The appropriate research strategy for critical research is **Retroduction** as it begins with a hypothetical mode of a mechanism that could explain the occurrence of a phenomenon under investigation.

- Critical theoretical approaches tend to rely on dialogic methods; methods combining observation and interviewing with approaches that foster conversation and reflection. This reflective dialogic allows the researcher and the participants to question the 'natural' state and challenge the mechanisms for order maintenance. This is a way to reclaim conflict and tension.
- Rather than naming and describing, the critical theorists try to challenge guiding assumptions.
- Critical theorists usually do this by beginning with an assumption about what is good (e.g. autonomy, democracy) and asking people in a social group, culture or organization to reflect on and question their current experience with regard to the values identified (e.g. To what extent are they an autonomous worker?)
- Critical theorists not only just try to describe a situation from a particular vantage point or set of values (e.g. the need for greater autonomy or democracy in a particular setting), but also try to change the situation.

“Objective” analysis

In their embrace of a normative perspective, Critical theorists make no claims that their analyses are “objective” in the sense usually meant by logical positivists. In fact, critical theorists argue that the subjective/objective dualism masks the ways in which both positions are limited by the social forces that inform all human action and analysis. Critical qualitative research acknowledges subjectivism in the sense that learnings and interpretations cannot be based on logic and scientific analysis only. While it affirms that knowledge can never be separated completely from the researcher’s own experience, it rejects the notion that all analyses are relative. It asserts that rational analysis is fundamental to human emancipation, and hence embraces what Morrow (1994) calls critical realism

Data analysis and verification

Critical researchers assume that their task is to expose the hidden assumptions that guide both research respondent statements and often, initial analyses of data. Researchers therefore bring a level of scrutiny to their task that includes rooting out the meanings of what is left unsaid as well as that which is stated. The research is verified as other members of the research community offer corroboration that has come from their own research experiences.

Sample representativeness, typicality, and generalizability

In a response similar to that of constructivism, critical researchers employing qualitative research would note that we are not seeking to explain the “typical” person, but to analyze that person’s possibilities and limits within a culture. In this approach, individuals are not seen as “types” or members of aggregate groups (although they may be both of these). Individuals instead are approached as beings that inhabit subject positions that are possible within a culture. Because individuals are members of society and must act within the society, they share certain understandings and meanings; if they did not, they could be considered insane, which in societal terms is the designation given to persons whose social realities have no seeming connection to those around them.

Validity

The test of validity in the case of critical constructivist research is directly related to its stated purpose of inquiry. The research is valid to the extent that the analysis provides insight into the systems of oppression and domination that limit human freedoms, and on a secondary level, in its usefulness in countering such systems.

Criticism

One of the charges against critical theory is its tendency toward elitism. With its proponents’ commitment to the idea that research can bring about a better and more equitable world, critics charge that critical theorists tend to assume that they are not only more capable of analyzing a situation than most; they are better equipped to offer a prescriptive plan of action. Critics charge that this often brings theorists outside of their realms of expertise so that the insights they offer are naive and unworkable in the contemporary setting.

Further, critics charge that critical theorists can be unwilling to listen to the experiences of those most adversely affected by current policies and the status

quo, as they tend to focus their analyses on persons and institutions in positions of power and authority. This, critics note, causes critical theorists to be out of touch with the very persons they purport to be most interested in helping.

Differences between critical theory framework and post-positivism on five major issues are as given below:

	Post-positivism	Critical Theory
Nature of reality	External to human mind	Material and external to the human mind.
Purpose of research	Find Universals	Uncover local instances of universal power relationships and empower the oppressed.
Acceptable methods and data	Scientific method	Subjective inquiry based on ideology and values; both quantitative and qualitative methods are acceptable.
Meaning of data	Falsification Use to test theory	Interpreted through ideology; used to enlighten and emancipate.
Relationship of research to practice	Separate activities. Research guides practice	Integrated activities. Research guides practice.

(Source: Foundations of qualitative research by Jerry W. Willis (2007))

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Is critical framework a departure from post-positivism and interpretivism? Give reasons in support of your answer?

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- 2) What points should be kept in mind while defining the methodology of critical research?

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- 3) Critical framework is sometimes known as the Frankfurt school. Why? Elaborate on the foundations of critical theory.

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5.4 APPLICATIONS IN RESEARCH: ILLUSTRATIVE CASES

Case 1: 'A study on 'invisible' labour-force in India

Invisible workforce comprises of care-workers who work daily for low/negligible wages however their work is critical to the success of the household/enterprise. Primarily constituting of housewives, nannies, cleaners, etc., these workers are engaged in 'care' work and their work is generally under-valued or over-looked. A news daily recently reported that as per Census 2011 figures nearly 160 million women in India aged between 15-59 years reported themselves as not working but were primarily involved in domestic work, care work and rearing families. In this case, the social actors are the housewives, nannies, cleaners, etc.

An interpretive researcher by using qualitative methods like phenomenology and symbolic interactionism would try to understand the root causes of such women not involved in economic work. Research could begin with penning down research questions like 'why the women have not taken up work outside home' or 'Are their social pressures for the women sticking to domestic work' or even 'Is the decision to work at home independent or curbed'. Next, the researcher can shortlist a region predominantly populated with invisible workers and use techniques of PRA/RRA to gather the requisite data. The perspectives on invisible work may differ among the social actors in this case too. For example if the researcher is probing the causes of invisible work he may observe that causes may be social, cultural or at times political too. It would be important to gather perspectives of not only unpaid care-workers but also their family members as to why they did not try to change their current situation, village head-men to understand whether it is due to lack of economic opportunities in the area and also to know whether illiteracy is the cause of invisibility of women workers.

Case 2: Absenteeism among students of primary school in rural areas

Universal primary education being one of the goals of Millennium Development Goals of UNDP, all developing countries are in the race of providing elementary and primary education to children in rural and urban areas. While enrolment in elementary and primary education has definitely increased in India in the last decade, but equally troublesome statistics have emerged quoting high incidence of absenteeism among students of primary school in certain rural areas. An interpretive researcher using qualitative methods and tools can take different perspectives of the social actors (read primary school children, teachers and parents) for absenteeism in primary schools.

Case 3: A study of employer's attitude towards distance/online-educated job applicants.

Distance educated youth are perceived to be less efficient and trained as compared to classroom educated youth. Instances of preferential bias have been observed in this respect often in the job market. An in-depth study on the employer's mindset can be undertaken by an interpretive researcher to explore the causes of the same. Extensive literature review is a pre-cursor to such research as that will underpin the historical causes of preferential attitude and negative perception of the employers. An interpretive researcher can employ actual observational techniques or use witness accounts of the interviews/interactions of the employer